

HEAVY EXPECTATIONS
CM Bhupendra Patel attends a meeting of newly elected party MLAs in Gandhinagar

ANI

GUJARAT

THE BURDEN ON BHUPENDRA

By Jumana Shah

The day Bhupendra Patel and his cabinet took oath, there were relaxed smiles all around. Gujarat's electorate had upturned the very notion of anti-incumbency with a whopping mandate for Prime Minister Narendra Modi's BJP. But as the euphoria of the election ebbs away, people reckon with the reality of the 'same' new government. To beat back any creeping sense of stasis, the state leadership has to maintain the tempo of 2022 till 2024, actively working on improving the economy, creating jobs and dealing with a bunch of contentious issues like EWS quota implementation and the Uniform Civil Code (UCC). The BJP has won all 26 Lok Sabha seats in Gujarat since 2014, its vote share increasing every time. Ensuring the trend continues rests squarely on Patel and his team now.

Gujarat's quest for a dynamic CM has been on since Modi left in 2014. Outsize shoes to fill, without doubt. But three faces in seven years is a sorry record even then—it has sent out a message of instability, as industry sources in Gujarat indicate. Business leaders admired Modi for the translation of political will into administrative action. In the past few years, that has been missing. "Anandiben Patel was removed unceremoniously amid the Patidar stir. Vijay Rupani lacked mass charisma, and his control over the administration was poor. We are hoping Bhupendrabhai will work," says an industry leader.

BJP'S CHALLENGES

- The tempo of the 2022 win has to be kept alive till 2024, with clear movement on all key policy fronts, including jobs
- Over 1 million government jobs are vacant. These must be filled up speedily, with the extra challenge of implementing EWS
- Files must move fast on the capital, interest and power subsidies promised to MSMEs
- The state has to navigate through tricky legislative areas: cattle control, UCC, 'love jihad'
- Inflation remains a concern

Patel is an urban leader, considered genial, sharp and articulate. Though he hasn't said much in his 15 months in office—his first mandate was to negotiate the election—those who have interacted with him claim he is better placed than Rupani at building the perception of an effective CM. Patel seems to have started off in the right spirit. After the grand swearing-in ceremony, portfolio allocation followed at a cabinet meeting that very Monday. And the CM and his cabinet hit office within 24 hours, a process that typically takes two-three days.

The cabinet of 16 is expected to expand after Uttarayan, January 14. Presently, it meets the need to have caste- and region-wise representation, with half a dozen first-timers thrown in. "Besides the CM, we expect three or four leaders to emerge organically as faces of this government. The way the Rupani cabinet was sacked, and two ministers right before the polls, everyone is hyper-conscious of the fact that they cannot slack off," admits a BJP leader.

Inflation and unemployment were very alive as factors before the election: they will need to be addressed. Inflation is not actually within the state's control, but it had reduced VAT on CNG and PNG by 10 percentage points in October 2022. Manufacturers heaved a sigh of relief, but government sources indicate the loss of VAT revenue is a real concern. "We cannot sustain it for long. It's a Catch-22 situation," says an official.

Before the polls, the government had also announced capital, interest